

LOCAL SPORTS

DISTRICT SWIMMING AND DIVING

Area athletes waiting, wondering about state

Five hoping for at-large berths might not find out until Monday afternoon

Paul Heyse
The Chronicle-Telegram

CLEVELAND — The next 24 hours will be a long, nervous wait for five area swimmers.

Firelands freshman Laura Clark, Bay senior Jamie Gomoll, Bay junior Meghan DeWees, Lutheran West senior Kristen Everhart of Elyria and Midpark junior Deanna Raedel will undoubtedly be checking the computer dozens of times between now and Monday afternoon.

The quintet of area swimmers are the most likely candidates to earn at-large berths to next weekend's state meet at Canton's C.T. Branin Natatorium.

Not one of them was able to qualify automatically, but the times should be good enough to earn at-large state berths. The top four finishers in the Division I boys district meet at CSU earned automatic state berths. The top five girls in Division I and the top three girls in Division II earned automatic state tickets.

Magnificat sophomore Christine Misterka of Westlake was the only area swimmer to earn an automatic individual state berth. Misterka placed fifth in the Division I girls 500 free (5:11.07). She rebounded after a lackluster race on Friday in the 200 free, placing 15th (2:00.53).

"I didn't swim my race on Friday," said Misterka, ninth in last year's district 500 free (5:18.15). "My coach told me to focus on my own race and not to worry about my competition. He told me to swim how I needed to. That's what I did. (Friday) I was watching too many people."

Magnificat junior Julie Reitenbach of Elyria earned a state ticket as a member of the Blue Streaks' fifth-place 200 free relay (1:40.59).

Clark placed sixth in Saturday's Division II girls 500 free (5:12.13) after placing sixth in Friday's 200 free (1:57.34). Gomoll placed sixth in the Division I boys 500 free (4:47.51). DeWees was sixth in Saturday's Division II girls 100 back (1:02.64). Everhart was seventh Friday in the 50 free (25.32). Raedel was seventh in the Division I girls 50 free (25.04).

Ordinarily, Clark, Gomoll, DeWees, Everhart and Raedel would learn of their fate by some time late this afternoon. Due to a snowstorm in southern Ohio, however, the Southwest district meet at Miami University scheduled for Friday was postponed until today.

So it's likely the five area swimmers won't know whether or not they qualified until Monday. The state swim meet seedings are posted on the Web site swimmeet.com. There are 11 at-large state berths available per event in the three divisions.

Clark was seeded only No. 8 in the 500 free, but managed to take sixth. She matched her seeding in the 200 free with a career-record time.

"I'm nervous," said Clark. "I really want to qualify. I'll probably be the first one on the computer to check and see. My mom will probably keep checking, too. We'll probably check it a lot."

Clark is hoping to become Firelands' first state qualifier in the four-year history of the school's swimming program.

"I came to the district meet last year to watch my sister compete," Clark said. "It's a high, pumped-up meet. It's much more exciting on deck than it is watching from the stands."

Kaitlin Clark, a junior and Laura's sister, is a three-time district qualifier in both the 100 back and 200 individual medley. She placed 11th in the 100 back in a personal-record time (1:04.24). Kaitlin took 14th in the 200 IM (2:18.60) on Friday.

Gomoll, seeded only No. 15, set a career-record time by 10 seconds. He beat his old mark of 4:56.75 set at last month's Canton Invitational. He placed 10th in Friday's 200 IM (2:00.37) in another personal-record time.

The most astonishing fact about Gomoll's performance in the 500 free was that he placed sixth while competing in the second-fastest heat (fourth of five heats). The Rocket senior hopes to become the Bay boys first state qualifier since Jason Hick qualified in the 100 breast in 1991.

"I'm just very happy with my time, no matter what, no matter if I qualify or not," Gomoll said. "I felt really good. I've been expecting stuff like that all season. Realistically, I was thinking somewhere around 4:50. I really didn't think I'd go that far under. I held pace really well and got into my groove, more than I have all season. I was able to stay in that groove and bring it home hard."

Last year, Gomoll placed only 33rd in the 500 free (5:10.48) and was 17th in the 200 IM (2:05.54).

Like Gomoll, DeWees enjoyed a personal-best performance in the 100 back as her placement matched her seeding. Last year, she placed 15th at the district (1:05.52). She eclipsed her previous best mark of 1:03.49 set at the Lakewood sectional.

"It's been a lot of hard work," DeWees said. "Last year I was just getting acquainted with the race and learning the basics. When I swam rec as a little kid I always was the backstroke on the medley relay. I've liked it for a long time."

year," said St. Ignatius coach Scott Pick. "The more shots he stopped, the more the Panthers knew they could take this game from us. He played an excellent game, as did his teammates. This was hockey at its best."

For the Panthers, they head into the off-season knowing they can play with the best.

"We are losing three seniors, so we are getting a lot of players back next year," said Badar. "Our younger players can build on this for next year. It's tough to lose a game like this, but we can hold our heads high. We have nothing to be ashamed of."

Elyria Catholic
St. Ignatius

Everhart was a state qualifier last year in the 50 free. She is the only one of the five at-large hopefuls with state meet experience, placing 19th last year (25.81). She posted a career-best time in taking seventh Saturday.

Last year, she got the final state berth with a slower time (25.57) after taking sixth at the CSU district. She also placed 10th in the 100 breast (1:11.72) in another career-best time.

BOYS

DIVISION I

Team scores: 1 University School, 293, 2 Firestone, 234 3 St Ignatius 163; 24 Bay, 20, 25 Berea 19 27 Avon Lake 18 29 Amherst 14 28 Westlake, 18, 42 Midpark, 3

(Top 4 finishers earn automatic state berths to next week's state meet at Canton)

100 free: 1 Tyler O'Halloran (Boardman), 45.44 2 Mark Levendort (University School) 47.17 3 Dave Okeson (West Geauga) 47.28 15 Adam Barkley (Berea), 50.12 29 Ryan Pulliam (Avon Lake), 51.20 30 Mike Lapalmento (Berea), 51.21 41 Brandon Mathus (Midpark), 51.88

500 free: 1 Steve Roof (Canton Central Catholic) 4:33.04 2 Omar Elgarni (Orange) 4:39.42 3 Ilya Byzov (University School), 4:39.68, 6 Jamie Gomoll (Bay), 4:47.51, 24 Craig Gary (St. Edward/Westlake resident), 5:05.84 28 John Connolly (Westlake) 5:09.50, 36 Alex de la Pena (Elyria Catholic), 5:12.69, 32 Aaron Snell (Berea) 5:14.49 49 Dave Gimno (North Olmsted) 5:23.70

200 free relay: 1 University School (Andy Neff, Mark Levendort, Arnaud Thibonnier, Robert Swanniger) 1:27.37, 2 St. Ignatius 1:27.48 3 North Canton Hoover 1:28.33 12 Berea (Todd Bush, Snell, Barkley, Lapalmento) 1:31.99 21 Avon Lake (Jim Weaver, Ron Loebeck, Jeff Conroy, Pulliam) 1:35.36

100 back: 1 Nathan King (Warren Harding) 52.69 2 An Markle (Mayfield) 54.28 3 Matt Wasserbauer (Hudson) 54.88 16 Weaver (Avon Lake) 58.25 17 Jack Hans (Berea) 58.66 34 Aaron Machala (North Olmsted) 1:00.83

100 breast: 1 Chns Ash (Firestone), 57.97 2 Will King (Firestone) 58.45 3 Steve Helmut (Louisville) 1:00.09 13 Ben Williams (Berea) 1:03.51 35 Mateo Chinchilla (North Olmsted) 1:07.73 43 Jim Alex (Bay), 1:07.18 46 Dan Donato (Elyria) 1:07.53

400 free relay: 1 University School (Levendort, Thibonnier, Drew Hoffman, Norm Ference) 3:14.62 2 Firestone 3:16.35 3 Warren Harding 3:18.84 24 North Olmsted (Machala, Chinchilla, Frank, Monon, Chad Bartok) 3:31.76 27 Olmsted Falls (Taylor Hardy, Kevin Anderson, Brett Wilhelm, Greg Miklich) 3:38.41 Berea disqualified

Friday

200 medley relay: 1 Firestone (Matt Whisman, King, Ryan Stoneburg, Andrew Guyton) 1:37.33 2 North Canton Hoover 1:38.69 3 Boardman 1:39.42 18 Berea (Jack Hans, Ben Williams, Jack Reiman, Snell) 1:44.87

200 free: 1 Roof (Canton Central Catholic) 1:41.34 2 Thibonnier (University School) 1:44.67 3 Byzov (University School) 1:45.60 19 Reiman (Berea) 1:50.63 26 Snell (Berea) 1:52.72 29 Gary (St. Edward) 1:53.15 46 Connolly (Westlake) 1:57.51

200 IM: 1 Nathan King (Warren Harding) 1:53.89 2 Andy Neff (University School) 1:55.42 3 Chns Ash (Firestone) 1:58.02 10 Gomoll (Bay) 2:00.37 27 Williams (Berea) 2:07.14 36 de la Pena (Elyria Catholic) 2:10.78

50 free: 1 O'Halloran (Boardman) 20.85 2 Okeson (West Geauga) 21.25 3 Drew Osaskow (North Canton Hoover) 21.28 24 Barkley (Berea) 23.01 31 Aaron Machala (North Olmsted) 23.177 37 Mike Lapalmento (Berea) 23.42

100 fly: 1 Neff (University School) 51.72 2 Chns Conway (St. Ignatius) 52.01 3 Jonathan Salibra (Mayfield) 52.38 26 Reiman (Berea) 56.78 28 Weaver (Avon Lake) 56.90 44 Brett Wieser (Elyria) 59.88 48 Ross Javornik (Amherst) 1:01.08

Thursday

Diving (top 8 divers qualify to Canton): 1 Jon Donadee (Canfield) 444.55 2 Ryan Novak (Avon Lake) 409.45 3 Dave Solarz (Westlake) 402.75 5 Derek Kokinda (Amherst) 393.10 10 Chns Rochford (Berea) 363.20 14 Jon Nguyen (Midpark) 350.15 24 Mike Von Duin (Midpark) 345.15

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BOYS BASKETBALL



TOM MAHL / CHRONICLE PHOTOS

BALL MEETS FACE: Amherst's Jacob Knipp is guarded closely by Vermilion's Brent Dover on Saturday in the Comets' 65-37 victory. Knipp scored nine and grabbed 14 rebounds.

Comets rout Sailors to cap great weekend

Tim Gebhardt
The Chronicle-Telegram

AMHERST — It wasn't for a conference or league crown.

Not even worth a higher seed for the upcoming tournament.

But what a sweet weekend just the same for the Amherst Comets.

Amherst completed a sweep of its Lorain County neighbors Saturday by drilling Vermilion, 65-37, in non-conference play.

It came on the heels of Friday's 60-52 Southwestern Conference victory over Avon Lake and raised the Comets' record to 10-9 overall. Vermilion finished the regular season at 3-17.

"Two wins against rivals coming into tournament time," said senior captain Nick Mihalic. "We'll take the momentum."

"These are two big rivals for our kids," said Amherst coach Mitch Gillam. "I thought we played pretty well."

There wasn't any phase of the game that Amherst failed to dominate. The Comets shot the ball extremely well — hitting half of their 16 3-point attempts — and 55 percent overall. The Comets had a healthy, 34-21, rebound edge, as well.

"We didn't do the things we've been working on in practice," said Vermilion coach Kurt Habermehl, "and it showed. We got too much individuals both offensively and defensively and we got blown out because of it."

"They're not in a very good (league) situation right now," Gillam said of the Sailors. "I'm sure it's tough to come in here with any confidence."

The Sailors failed to win any of their 12 Heartland Conference games and were blown away by Ashland, 87-41, Friday night.

On Saturday, an early 13-point run by Amherst made sure Vermilion wasn't going to change its luck. Mihalic had a hand — literally — in the first-quarter blitz that broke a 4-4 tie. A steal and layup by the 5-foot-7 bundle of hustle was followed by a pair of long-range 3-pointers to put Amherst ahead 17-4.

"We knew what (Amherst) was going to do," Habermehl said. "We had to stop the penetration. If you can stop the penetration, you can prevent them from kicking it back out and shooting the threes. We didn't do a very good job of it."

"That's part of our offense," said Mihalic. "Drive in. Collapse the defense. We know everyone on the team can shoot. That's what we have to



RELEASE, ROTATION: Amherst's Nick Mihalic drives for a layup after a steal Saturday night in the first half.

do — hit the open shots."

Vermilion never got closer than 10 points the rest of the night.

"We did a pretty good job," Gillam said. "We're going to miss (Mihalic) next year. He's what high school basketball is all about."

"He's improved a lot since his sophomore year just by working hard. He hustles all the time. Everybody loves him."

Mihalic led the scoring for Amherst with 14 points — drilling four treys. Wes Imler tossed in three 3-pointers and scored 13. Greg Peltz finished with 10 points and Jacob Knipp nine to go with his 14 rebounds.

Nick Roninger (17 points) and Brent Dover (12) led the Sailors, but only two others managed to score. Vermilion made only 12 field goals in 40 tries (30 percent).

Vermilion faces Oak Harbor in the Sandusky Division II tournament Feb. 26. Amherst closes the regular season at Olmsted Falls on Friday before meeting Westlake Feb. 24 at Midview in Division I tournament play.

VERMILION (37): Brent Dover 3-4 12 Tim Allen 3-0-6 Nick Roninger 5-6-17, Nick Esposito 1-0-2, Sean Liljeberg 0-0-0, Sam Deason 0-0-0 Jason Colstrup 0-0-0, Jake Kaple 0-0-0, Seth Haggel 0-0-0 Ryan Alsop 0-0-0 Mark Novak 0-0-0 Totals 12